



Vetting the Broker

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 7 of 18 · Finding & Judging the Load · about a 15-minute read

Here's a story that happens to good carriers every week. You find a load with a great rate, you book it, Marcus hauls it a thousand miles, delivers it perfectly, you send the invoice — and then nothing. Calls go unreturned. When you finally dig in, you learn the "broker" who handed you that load wasn't the real company at all. Someone set up an email one letter off a legitimate brokerage's name, gave your load out, collected from the shipper, and vanished. The load was double-brokered. Summit just ran a thousand miles, burned a tank of fuel, and paid a driver — for free.

Here's what stings: *everything operational was flawless*. Right truck, on time, clean delivery. The one thing that got skipped was the cheapest step of all — checking who you were really dealing with before you committed the truck.

You can do every other part of this job perfectly and still lose the whole load if the money never shows up or the broker's a fraud. Vetting is the five-minute habit that protects all the rest of it.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Take any broker — especially one you've never worked with — and quickly answer three questions before you commit your truck: Are they a real, authorized broker? Will they actually pay me? And is anything here a red flag for fraud? You'll have a simple checklist you run every time, so a bad load never gets past you.

1 The Last Gate, and Why It's Non-Negotiable

You've found a load worth chasing and confirmed your driver can deliver it on time. There's one move left before you say yes, and it's the one new dispatchers skip because they're excited to book: you are about to hand your truck, your driver's week, and a real chunk of money to a *stranger*. If that stranger doesn't pay — or isn't who they claim to be — you eat the entire loss. Operational perfection doesn't matter if the money never comes.

The good news is that freight is a surprisingly *transparent* business. Brokers operate under public federal licenses, their payment reputations are tracked, and the warning signs of fraud follow predictable patterns. So vetting isn't guesswork — it's a short, repeatable checklist you run on every new broker, and spot-check on the ones you already trust. Let's build it.

2 Is This Broker Real and Authorized?

First question: is this a legitimate, licensed broker at all? Remember those federal numbers from the very first lesson — the **MC number** and **DOT number**, issued by the **FMCSA**, the federal agency that regulates trucking? This is where you finally *use* them.

Every legitimate broker holds **broker operating authority** from the FMCSA — basically a federal license to arrange freight — and it's tied to their MC number. And here's the tool that makes this easy: **SAFER**, the FMCSA's free public website. You can look up any broker or carrier by name, MC, or DOT number and see their record. A real record looks like this:

SAFER • Company Snapshot — what you're checking	
LEGAL NAME SMITH LOGISTICS LLC	MUST MATCH THE RATE CON name • address • MC #
MC NUMBER MC-123456	DOT NUMBER USDOT 1234567
OPERATING AUTHORITY ACTIVE ✓	AUTHORITY TYPE Broker
A HARD STOP INSTEAD REVOKED / INACTIVE ✗	A FRAUD SIGNAL info doesn't match ✗

Two things only:

Is their authority active? It should say active — not revoked, not pending, not inactive. A revoked or missing authority is a hard stop.

Does the information match? The legal company name, the address, and the MC number on their record should match what they told you and what's on the paperwork they sent. A mismatch is one of the biggest fraud signals there is — because the number-one scam is someone *impersonating* a real, authorized broker.

That's the foundation: a real broker, with active authority, whose identity checks out against the official record. Notice the theme already — you're verifying against the *government's record*, not against what's written in an email. We'll come back to why that matters so much.

3 Will They Actually Pay You?

Being licensed is not the same as paying on time. So the second question is about your money, and it has two parts.

Part one — the bond

Federal law requires every broker to carry a **broker bond** — currently a seventy-five-thousand-dollar surety bond, often called by its form name, the **BMC-84**. It exists for exactly one reason that benefits *you*: if a broker fails to pay the carriers it owes, those carriers can file a claim against that bond to try to recover. So part of vetting is confirming the broker has an **active bond**. No bond, or a lapsed one, is a serious red flag.

One honest caveat: that seventy-five thousand is shared across *everyone* the broker stiffes, so it's a safety net, not a guarantee of full payment — and the exact amount is set by regulation, so confirm the current figure. But its presence is a baseline you check.

Part two — do they actually pay, and how fast?

This is the deep version of that quick glance you took at the posting. A broker's **payment reputation** is tracked and visible — usually as a **credit score** and a **days-to-pay** number, pulled from load boards or credit services, plus what other carriers say. The durable read: a strong score and reasonable days-to-pay — paying somewhere in the standard thirty-day range — is a green light. A weak score, or very slow pay like forty-five-plus days, or an outright history of nonpayment, is a yellow-to-red flag. It doesn't always mean "never haul for them" — sometimes it means "haul, but protect yourself," which we'll see in a moment. But you always *look* before you commit.

CONFIRM CURRENT FMCSA REQUIREMENTS

The seventy-five-thousand-dollar bond is today's standard, but dollar figures and rules are set by regulation and can change. Treat the number as a checkpoint, not gospel — what never changes is the habit of confirming a bond is active before you haul.

4 Spotting Fraud: the Red Flags

Now the part that protects you from outright scams. Specific fraud schemes change every year, so don't memorize tricks — learn the *patterns*, because those don't change. Slow down and look closer whenever you see any of these:

The five durable red flags

- 1. A rate that's too good to be true.** Well above the going rate for the lane, with no good reason. That's bait — the oldest one there is.
- 2. Pressure to skip steps.** "Just send the truck, we'll sort the paperwork later." Urgency that rushes you past your checklist is a warning, not a courtesy.
- 3. Contact info that doesn't match the record.** A free email instead of a company domain, a phone not on their FMCSA record, an address that's a real brokerage's name with one letter changed. This is impersonation — the most common fraud in freight.
- 4. "Send it to a different company."** Being asked to send the load, paperwork, or invoice to a different name than the one on the rate con. That's the classic sign of **double-brokering**.
- 5. Reluctance to give basic, verifiable info** — their MC number, a proper rate con, a real address.

And here's the one principle that ties all of it together, the single most important habit in this whole lesson: **verify identity from the official FMCSA record, not from what's in the email or the posting.** A scammer controls what their email says; they do not control the government's record. When something feels off, you stop and check — because a load you miss costs you a day, and a load you haul for a fraud costs you the whole thing.

5 The Vetting Checklist

Put it together into the checklist you run before committing to any new broker:

- 1 **Authority.** Look them up on SAFER. Is the authority active, and does their info match the paperwork?
- 2 **Bond.** Confirm they carry an active broker bond.
- 3 **Pay.** Check the credit score and days-to-pay. Do they pay, and how fast?
- 4 **Red flags.** Scan for the patterns — too-good rate, pressure, mismatched contact, "send it to a different name."
- 5 **Get it in writing.** A signed rate con from the verified company before the truck moves. *(That document is its own lesson, but it's the close of vetting.)*

Pass the checklist, and you haul with confidence. A broker who's real, bonded, and pays — that's a green light. A broker who's authorized and bonded but pays slowly might be a "haul, but factor the invoice or ask for quick-pay" — protect yourself. And a broker who throws red flags, won't verify, or isn't active on SAFER? You don't haul, no matter how good the rate looks. Brokers you've worked with and trust just need a quick re-check, not the full run every time.

Walkthrough — Vetting Three Brokers

The anchor load is on the board. Should Summit commit? Run each broker through the checklist.

Broker A — Smith Logistics (the broker on our furniture load)

SAFER: authority **ACTIVE**; name / MC / address match the rate con ✓ Bond: active ✓

Pay: credit **92**, pays ~25 days ✓ No red flags. Signed rate con in hand ✓

→ **CLEAR** — haul it with confidence.

Broker B — "great rate, hurry"

Rate: \$1/mi over market for the lane — suspiciously high. Pressure: "send the truck now, paperwork later."

Contact: emails from a free Gmail address, one letter off a known brokerage's name. Ask: "send the POD to a different company than the one on the load."

→ **MULTIPLE RED FLAGS** — almost certainly impersonation / double-brokering. STOP. Verify against the FMCSA record. Do **not** haul.

Broker C — real, but slow (the judgment call)

SAFER: active ✓ Bond: active ✓

Pay: low credit score, pays 60+ days, some carrier complaints.

→ **HAUL ONLY WITH PROTECTION** (factor the invoice / require quick-pay) — or pass. "Authorized" is not the same as "pays well."

Three brokers, three different answers. Broker A clears every step — a green light. Broker B looks great *only* on the rate, and falls apart the moment you check the record — that's exactly the load that ends like our cold open, and you walk away. Broker C is the real-world gray area: legitimate, but slow and shaky on payment, so you either protect your money or skip it. The checklist turns all three from a gut feeling into a clear decision — before the truck moves.

Module 7 Glossary — your quick reference

The vetting toolkit, in one place.

Authority & identity

SAFER	The FMCSA's free public lookup — search any broker or carrier by name, MC, or DOT to see their official record.
Operating authority	The FMCSA license to operate — a broker's is the federal permission to arrange freight, tied to their MC number.
MC number	Motor Carrier number issued by the FMCSA — the broker's license ID you verify on SAFER.
DOT number	USDOT number identifying a regulated company in FMCSA records.
FMCSA	Federal Motor Carrier Safety Administration — the agency that licenses and regulates brokers and carriers.

Getting paid & protected

Broker bond (BMC-84)	A federally required surety bond (currently \$75,000). If a broker doesn't pay its carriers, they can claim against it — a safety net, shared across all unpaid carriers.
Payment reputation	How well and how fast a broker pays — tracked as a credit score and a days-to-pay figure, plus carrier word-of-mouth.
Double-brokering	When someone re-brokers a load they have no right to — the carrier hauls but the money disappears with the middleman. A core fraud to spot.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **Where do you verify a broker is legitimately authorized, and what two things are you checking?**
2. **What is the broker bond, and why does it matter to you as the carrier's dispatcher?**
3. **A broker offers a rate well above market, pressures you to send the truck now, emails from a Gmail one letter off a real brokerage's name, and asks you to send the POD to a different company. What's likely going on, and what do you do?**
4. **A broker is active on SAFER and bonded, but has a low credit score and pays in 60+ days. Do you take the load?**
5. **Name three steps of the vetting checklist, and state the one principle that ties them together.**

ANSWERS

1. On SAFER (the FMCSA's free public lookup). Check that their broker authority is active, and that their company name / MC / info match the paperwork they sent.
2. A federally required surety bond (currently \$75,000, the BMC-84). If the broker doesn't pay its carriers, carriers can claim against it to try to recover. Confirm it's active — no or lapsed bond is a red flag. It's shared across all unpaid carriers, so it's a safety net, not a guarantee.
3. Classic impersonation / double-brokering fraud. Stop; verify the broker's identity against the official FMCSA record (not the email); do not haul.
4. Only with protection — factor the invoice or require quick-pay — or pass. Authorized and bonded is not the same as pays well.
5. Any three of: check authority on SAFER; confirm an active bond; check credit / days-to-pay; scan for red flags; get a signed rate con. Principle: verify identity from the official FMCSA record, not from the email or posting.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 8: THE BOOKING CALL

That's the end of judging. Stop and see how far you've come: you can find a load worth chasing, confirm your driver can legally deliver it on time, and verify the broker is real and will pay. Everything up to now has been *deciding whether* to go after a load. Now you go *get* it. Next, we make the call that turns a posting on a screen into a booked load on your truck — the booking call. This is where all that phone presence we built starts to pay off.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches vetting with generic standards and the official-record principle. Your own operation adds its specifics — the exact tools it uses to check authority, bonds, and credit; its minimum acceptable credit score and maximum days-to-pay before requiring protection; its approved-broker and do-not-load lists; its fraud-response procedure and who to escalate to the moment a load smells like double-brokering; and how often to re-vet a repeat broker. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*